

Introduction

Over the past week, I have spent my vacation from school on the *Celebrity Eclipse*, sailing through the Caribbean and stopping at small island nations. It was a wonderful time, but I honestly have found that the time I spent on board actually may have provided some knowledge, both for my personal life and for MST. I met many interesting people on board and attended some events that were informative. I thought that I would share what I have learned, so that it might be applied to MST and to MSTI as an organization. I did engage in some light reading as well, so I will incorporate some of this here too.



The Celebrity Eclipse

Architecture: Observation and Thoughts

From day one, the architecture on this ship impressed me, even with it being an older ship than those that I have been on before. Of course, MST is not really about building, but maybe some of these thoughts could be adapted to fit MSTI or for builds relating to it. Feel free to skip this if you don't find the value in it. Certain aspects in particular caught my attention, so I think that I should give them some special attention here:

Glass Elevators: This was one of my favorite parts of the ship, as it ran directly from the top from the bottom and gave you a complete view of what went on in the center. It is completely open from the bottom to the top, so when music is played at the bottom you can hear it from anywhere. The common areas are on the top and bottom of the ship, but those few quiet areas near the elevators in the middle are really quiet to sit and watch the elevators from. I would love to see something similar in a Minecraft base, but I don't know how hard that might be.



The elevators and central space (I apologize for the poor quality from my iPad)

No 13th Floor: This I found very interesting, but I am aware that this is not a feature unique to just this ship, rather, it is a common feature in architecture. People write it off as superstitious to not include/name the 13th floor, but I find it kind of cool that many architects agree on this minor detail. It makes me think of MSTI, and how it would be cool if we could come up with a few minor things we all do as writers/creators, or even at some point make a build which could be used by creators that symbolizes MSTI (We would not need a server, but a large build for a MSTI HQ would be very cool).



Yep, no 13th floor here.

A smaller number of larger common spaces: I didn't necessarily like or dislike this part. For example, on this ship there is only one main dining room, while on other ships there might be multiple with different themes that are each smaller. I find this detail interesting, and I found that this is true even for the staff. It appears to encourage an egalitarian form of interaction with others on board, since there is no division of people based on class. Relationships were formed between all classes of people, and I find this part very cool and interesting. It makes me think about how shared infrastructure, like that of this ship and what could be MSTI, encourages or discourages unique relationships based on its design. I take this as a sort of warning for MSTI, as we should likely refrain from creating classes or many private chat areas. I still feel that general division might still help with organization, but thoughts from one department need to be able to spread to others (just as I am doing now).



The one lounge area is pretty big, as can be seen in this photo

A Stop at San Juan, Puerto Rico

One of the only destinations we got off at, and the only one I feel that is worth mentioning here because it made me think of a couple things that I found interesting.

Without going too deep into this or being political, it was hard to believe that it is a US territory. There is a lot of damage from hurricanes that FEMA has not helped with because of their lack of statehood. They don't have any representation at the federal level either. I get that generally we want to keep real life separate from MSTI, but problems like this are not hard to solve, and though we can't solve them, we might be able to help by way of making people think. This is just a thought, but I don't think this is too far fetched and people are doing it already. Give people the adjacent knowledge and confidence to question what is going on.



San Juan, Puerto Rico

A Book I Read A Bit: *Thinking in Systems*

As promised, I am going to include a short section here of what I have found out so far from this book, and honestly, I would highly recommend reading it for MST.

The basis of the book is what it sounds like; it is about approaching problem solving in a different way. It talks about systems, which it roughly defines as any set of elements (which themselves could be sub-systems) which interact to achieve some function or purpose. Of course, using this definition, MSTI is a system, Minecraft is a system, the YouTube interaction is a system, etc. I immediately thought of how this could be applied to both MST in general and MSTI as an organization. Here are a few notes based on the little that I actually got from reading the book.

Look Beyond Cause and Effect: This is a point that the book makes early on, and it is a mistake that I have been trying to point out but I could not find the exact words, but the book actually did a very good job explaining this. The book uses the example of the OPEC oil shortage in the United States, and how poor policy decisions were made to try to defeat the cause of the problem. Instead of resolving the issue, it only made things worse, and the US failed to see the real problem, which was poor design of logistics and dependency. Systems are complex, and you cannot predict cause and effect. Often, you need to figure out how elements of the system interact to find the true problem.

Systems are hard to Understand: This brings us to our next point, which can become somewhat obvious quickly. Systems are made up of both elements (abstract and/or physical) and the connections between them. To fully understand a system, you need to understand all the connections between said elements, not just how the elements work. Going further with this point, the hardest part to understand is actually the true function, which is what the system actually does (not necessarily what it wants to do). The function can usually be reliably found exclusively by observation.

No Element of a System is More Important to Function Than Another: This is likely somewhat controversial, but as the book said, to ask the question of importance is to ask an unsystematic question. In terms of the actual function of a system (again, not what it wants to accomplish) every element contributes to the function, and a fundamental removal of an element changes the function. While this holds true, you can change the specific element, i.e. one professor for another, without changing the function of the system as long as the function of that element did not change. If the new professor has the same job, title, and hierarchy, the function of the system should not change.

A Final Run before Getting Off

Just a fair warning to you all, this section might get a little bit deeper than some might appreciate. I got close to pondering the meaning of life here or something, so feel free to skip this section if that does not appeal to you.

It was my last night on the ship, and I had just finished with the last activity of the cruise. Back in the room, I had a sudden urge to run, which I had not had since before I left Maine. Back home, I am in cross country and I identify as a distance runner, usually doing 5k races. I wanted this vacation off from running, however, and I followed through with that units the last day.

I went up to the top deck where there was a running track, and I just ran for about 20 minutes, and I got to thinking. The ship was well lit on the top deck, but it occurred to me looking off the ship as I ran that it was very dark in every direction off of the ship. In the distance, you could see dots of light, likely coming from other ships, but otherwise it was pitch black. I figured that we were the only light for many miles in all directions, and the only break in the darkness of the night.

This seemed to me a metaphor, both for life and for MSTI. Darkness is like emptiness in the universe, of which we are only a little dot. We know that we are in the light because we can see, but it makes you think that some might not be. To explain this with MSTI, I feel that we are on something like a ship in a dark ocean. We don't really know where we are going, but we are going forward. This might evolve or stay the same, but our small communitiy is the only one like it to exist, or that might ever exist again for all that I know. I have been a part of many communities that have failed, so it makes me think about how we are only but a speck of light in the YouTube community. Of course, our lights may grow or blaze brighter, but will we ever fill the darkness? More importantly, does everyone get to enjoy the light?

I will leave you to ponder that, or not, if you wish. Now, I thought, I might not ever share this, and this moment will never happen again. MSTI might not be as serious as I make it seem, but never again will this group of people come together for this new thing. What is exciting is that we are doing something different, and we have a chance at changing the entire Minecraft community, and I would even say that we could make a difference in real life too, even if we don't know it.



The view from the ship on the last night

Conclusion

Whether or not you enjoyed what I thought while I was gone, I thought that it would be nice to have a little relic to leave behind from my trip, so that it might inspire others to do the same. If you look for it, you can see MSTI in the real world, and maybe they aren't as different as they seem. Whether or not we decide to reform MSTI, or if we even remember, if I even remember, what was said in this document, I believe that the experience of the cruise and MSTI are life changing experiences and perspectives that I hope you might decide to internalize if you wish it so. Sorry if that was too nerdy, but I don't want to regret not writing.

Thank you to everyone who helped me navigate through this busy period in my life. MSTI makes it all worth it, and I look forward to seeing you all around.

To a better future for us, the Minecraft community, and the real world!

Turtle